

strokeplay. Centuries from Yashasvi Jaiswal, Joe Root and Harry Brook bore testimony to the balance.

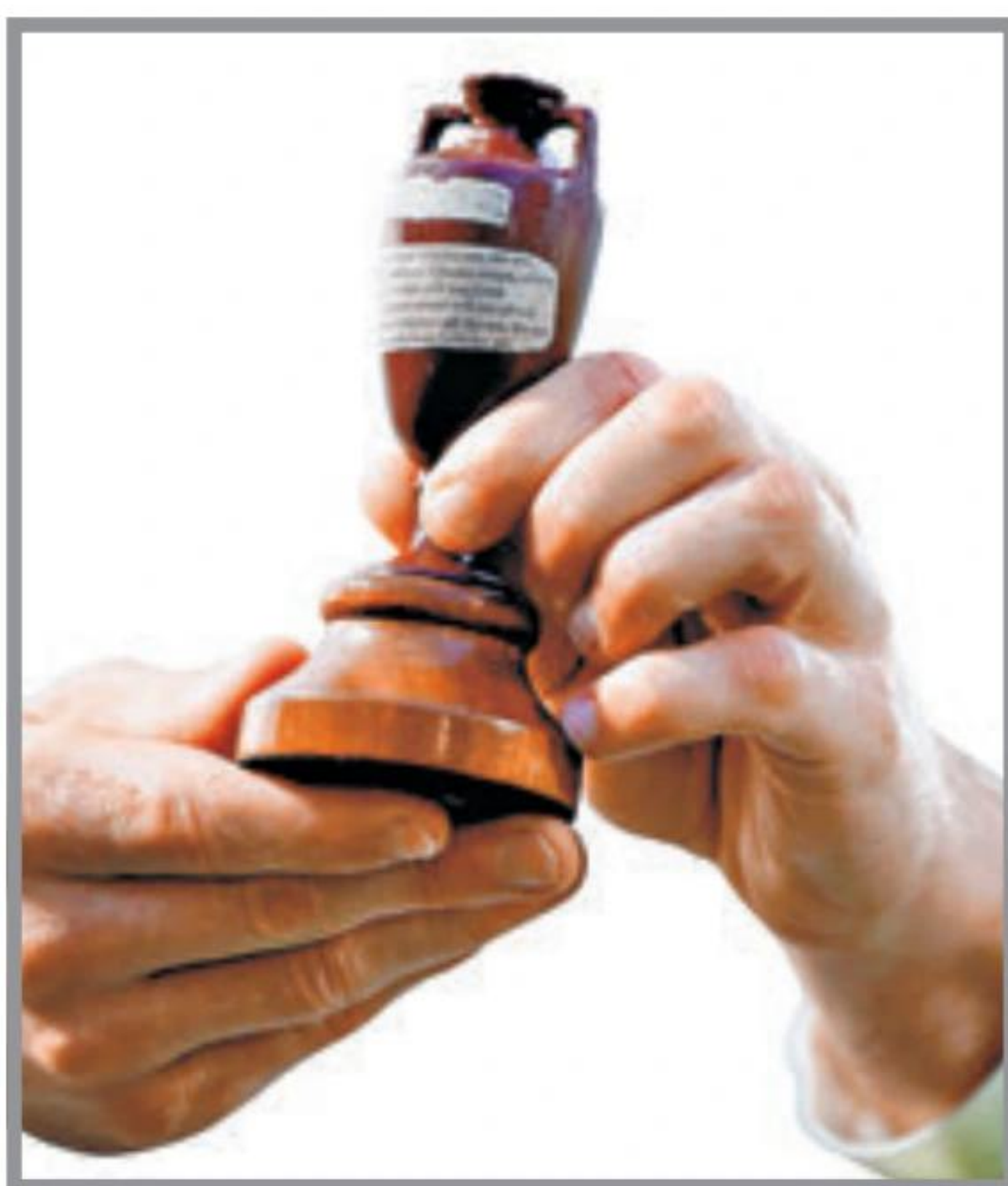
Between sessions, Fortis was the first to assess the pitch, working hands-on with his groundstaff to preserve its lively character. Run-ins with coaches or captains are not new for him; he's fiercely possessive of his turf.

When the match ended, with India pulling off a dramatic six-run win to level the series, Fortis congratulated the bowlers. Later that evening, he was back on his favourite staircase, sipping tea. "We play 60 days of cricket here. It's not easy. But such things happen— part of the game," he said with a grin. "You all enjoyed the game, no? That's my biggest prize."

He posed for selfies with travelling journalists and exchanged pleasantries with Indian players. All's well that ends well.

Slice of history

On August 29, 1882, The Ashes was born at The Oval after England's shock defeat to Australia. The *Sporting Times* mock obituary lamented the "death of English cricket", proclaiming that "the body will be cremated and the Ashes



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taken to Australia".

That history still lingers. A plaque near the Jack Hobbs gate commemorates the moment, while another, near the main pavilion, marks the first-ever FA Cup final,



Emotional tribute: A poignant moment as Graham Thorpe's family leads the bell-ringing ceremony at The Oval, remembering a beloved cricketer and coach.

REUTERS

played at The Oval on March 16, 1872. The Wanderers beat Royal Engineers 1-0. Twenty-one more finals were held here before The Oval became an exclusive cricket ground.

The museum, usually reserved for Surrey members, was opened to the public during the final Test. Fans poured in to catch a glimpse of cricket's deep roots.

A day for Thorpey

Day Two of the Oval Test was dedicated to Graham Thorpe, the former England batter who died last August after being struck by a train in Surrey. The coroner ruled the death a suicide.

It was, fittingly, "A Day for Thorpey". Players wore headbands bearing his silhouette and initials during training. His wife, Amanda, and daughter, Emma, rang the bell before play.

Root looked visibly emotional. Ben Stokes spoke movingly: "Thorpey was influential as a player and a coach. Many of us came through the ranks under his guidance, and he remained involved when we entered the main team."

Surrey, Thorpe's County team, paid tribute with a mural outside the

ground. It was a dignified remembrance of a quiet craftsman, 6,744 Test runs at 44.66, whose impact stretched beyond statistics.

(Those who require assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts may contact Sanjivini, Society for Mental Health suicide prevention helpline 011-4076 9002 (10 a.m. to 7.30 p.m., Monday-Saturday))

Tu la parat man la re, Siraj

In 15 years of travel, The Diary had seen many press boxes, but never one like this.

On day five, as Mohammed Siraj brought India within reach of victory, the press box turned into a fan zone. Grown men were in tears. As Gus Atkinson and Chris Woakes added each run, superstition crept in. Reporters were told not to leave their seats. Those returning from the toilet were rebuked. Nobody wanted to tempt fate. Then, as Siraj cleaned up Atkinson, the press box rose as one. A veteran Marathi journalist captured the mood best: "*Tu la parat man la re, Siraj...*" (You've won my heart again, Siraj.)

It was a tearful, joyous finale to a series that swayed wildly, sometimes fraying nerves, always stirring the soul.